

Her fluent half-century was slowly culminating in a ton, but Deepti cut the batter's innings short at a 56-ball 90 and handed India a 36-run win.

London 2017: England - 228/7; India - 219 | England won by nine runs

The 2017 World Cup final was a case of so close, and yet so far for India, as it fell agonisingly short of winning its maiden World Cup title.

For large parts of the match, it seemed that India was in control, keeping a lid on the runs with some tight bowling to prevent England from posting a large total. When Nat Sciver-Brunt fell for 51 to make the score 164/6, India appeared well positioned to limit the host to a low total. But a flurry of lower-order runs eventually pushed England to 228-7.

India started its chase well, and when Punam Raut and Harmanpreet Kaur were batting, it needed less than 100 runs with eight wickets in hand. However, starting with Harmanpreet, England slowly chipped away at the wickets to haul itself back into the game. Anya Shrubsole was the pick of the English bowlers, and it was her sixth wicket — a delivery that rattled into Rajeshwari Gayakwad's off stump — that ultimately sealed England's nine-run victory and the trophy.

Mount Maunganui, 2022: West Indies - 259/9; New Zealand - 256 | WI won by three runs

What better way to start a World Cup than with a thriller that goes to the last over? The last edition kicked off exactly like that.

After winning the toss, the Kiwis asked the Windies to bat at the Bay Oval in Mount Maunganui. Experienced pacer Lea Tahuu laid a marker for things to come by sending back Deandra Dottin in just the third over. She and Jess Kerr steadily removed West Indies batters one by one, but opener Hayley Matthews stayed on.

She laboured to her third ODI century, peppering the outfield with 16 boundaries and clearing it once, and only departed the crease in the 45th over. West Indies, riding on Matthews' ton, posted 259.

If Matthews' knock accounted for



much of her team's total, Sophie Devine did just that for the host. She notched up her sixth ODI ton and New Zealand took the match to the final over. Up to that point, Matthews herself and Anisa Mohammed had taken two wickets apiece. The Kiwis needed six runs from the last over. Katey Martin and Kerr were at the crease and Dottin was to bowl the final six balls. In remarkable fashion, the West Indies all-rounder sent both batters back in the second and fourth deliveries. Fran Jonas was run out on the penultimate ball to cap off a three-run win for the Windies.

Christchurch, 2022: India - 274/7; South Africa - 275/7 | SA won by three wickets

Semifinal qualification for the 2022 World Cup went right down to the last ball of the group stage, with India facing South Africa at Christchurch knowing that only victory would be enough to knock out West Indies and secure a spot in the final four.

After winning the toss and opting to bat first, Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma produced a bright start for India, scoring 91 inside 15 overs. Mithali Raj and Harmanpreet Kaur both added useful runs as well, and though there was a late-overs

Devastating finish: South Africa's Mignon du Preez hit the winning runs to send India out of the 2022 edition.

slowdown, India ended its innings on an impressive 274/7, requiring South Africa to complete its highest-ever chase.

The South African chase got off to an inauspicious start as Lizelle Lee was run out early, but contributions from Laura Wolvaardt, Lara Goodall, and Marizanne Kapp kept it in the hunt. With five overs remaining, South Africa needed 45 runs with five wickets in hand, including Mignon du Preez and Chloe Tryon at the crease. A flurry of boundaries were then followed by Tryon's dismissal, and Deepti Sharma was tasked with defending seven runs from the final over.

The equation had reduced to three runs required from the final two balls when du Preez holed out to long-on, only to be rescued by the third umpire's call that Deepti had overstepped. Du Preez finished the match off the final delivery to send India out, and West Indies through to the semifinals, in the process completing South Africa's highest ODI chase.